dismantling and removal of the missiles on behalf of the UN or through it and provide the United Nations with intelligence information on the location and status of the sites.

Kennedy wanted the IL-28 Soviet airplanes out of Cuba as well. They were old and outdated but still capable of delivering nuclear bombs to US territory and thus constituted a threat. As such, they could be included in the "offensive weapons" category established in Kennedy's statement on the discovery of the SAM missiles in early September. During a meeting with his advisers on October 20, Kennedy had declared that he did not care about Soviet airplanes on the island, and that they all "must be prepared to live with the Soviet threat as represented by Soviet bombers." But now things had changed. No longer being hunted by Khrushchev, he had become a hunter in his own right, and Khrushchev was on the run. Bombers reentered the picture, but Kennedy decided not to raise the question immediately lest the issue derail his missile deal with Khrushchev. Everyone was in agreement. Kennedy asked the members of ExCom to avoid exuberant public comments—the crisis was not yet over.[5]

The letter to Khrushchev that Kennedy signed later that day was nothing like those he had previously sent to Moscow. They had been prepared after long discussions with aides, agonizing over what to say and which of Khrushchev's arguments to address. Nor were there any references to past deceptions or misdeeds, but there was an apology for Captain Maultsby's inadvertent foray into Soviet airspace. "I think that you and I, with our heavy responsibilities for the maintenance of peace, were aware that developments were approaching a point where events could have become unmanageable," wrote Kennedy.

The president continued, expressing his understanding of what constituted a deal and indicating his commitment to it: "I consider my letter to you of October twenty-seventh and your reply of today as firm undertakings on the part of both governments which should be promptly carried out." Finally, he responded positively to Khrushchev's offer to continue discussions on nuclear disarmament. "I think we should give priority to questions relating to the proliferation of nuclear weapons, on earth and in outer space, and to the great effort for a nuclear test ban," wrote Kennedy. He was ready to move beyond the Cuban crisis by returning to